Group 2 — Build It: protect it with dollars

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Our position: Nobody disputes who owns Toronto. That is because people live there, work there, and ships dock there. Sovereignty is not a submarine; it is a port, a road, a mine, and a town that can keep its lights on. The old Canadian slogan was "use it or lose it." We say: build it, and the ownership question answers itself.

Briefing

The federal government has, for the first time in a generation, put serious money behind this idea. On March 3, 2026, Transport Minister Steven MacKinnon announced a $1 billion Arctic Infrastructure Fund alongside a $5 billion Trade Diversification Corridors Fund (Arctic Portal, Mar. 6, 2026). The Arctic fund pays for "dual-use" projects: roads, airports and ports that serve both the military and the community, with priority for projects finished by the end of 2028 (Transport Canada; Dentons, Mar. 2026). The March 16 northern plan added about $10 billion in major projects: the 800 km Mackenzie Valley Highway, the Grays Bay Road and Port in Nunavut, and the $1 billion Arctic Economic and Security Corridor, which would extend Canada's road and rail network right up to Northwest Passage shipping lanes (ReNew Canada, Mar. 16, 2026; North of 60 Mining News, Feb. 2026).

The prize underneath is critical minerals. Grays Bay would pair a deepwater port with a 230 km all-season road into the West Kitikmeot region, where copper, zinc, lead, silver and likely gallium and germanium sit in the ground (Geoconversation, May 28, 2026; North of 60, Jan. 2026). Nunavut's premier has called the territory "Canada's gateway to the Northwest Passage." In May 2026, Energy Minister Tim Hodgson announced a further $55 million for Grays Bay and for a low-emissions pilot at the B2Gold mine, saying Canada must be a trusted mining power as Arctic routes grow in importance (Natural Resources Canada, May 20, 2026).

The global demand is real. China has used critical minerals as a pressure point in trade disputes, and the 2026 Iran war disrupted Gulf shipping, pushing countries to look for alternative sources and routes (Steptoe, June 2026). Russia's Northern Sea Route carried over 30 million tonnes in recent years and began scheduled China–Europe container service in August 2026; the Northwest Passage saw just 13 full transits in 2025 (Aker Arctic, Oct. 2025). To this group, that gap is not a reason to give up. It is the business case.

> "Russia didn't win the Arctic shipping race with warships. They won it with 40 ports, a nuclear icebreaker fleet, and a government that treated the North as a place to live, not a place to guard." — *Marguerite Lacasse, Arctic shipping analyst* **[illustrative]**

Quotations marked [illustrative] are fictional composite voices written for readability. Real public figures are paraphrased from the linked reports.